

The Hours Left Over

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Martin Arce

Chapter 1

At 03:12 the city still looked like a machine that had forgotten how to power down. Tram lines hissed blue over wet pavement. Delivery drones crossed above Gran Via like metal swifts while ad fog climbed the glass towers in translucent layers of branded weather. Whole office floors burned white behind smart windows, and between them ran the thin traffic of maintenance bridges, couriers, and contract medics. People moved with the smooth, depthless energy Vigil had given everybody four years earlier. The old language remained out of habit. We still said dawn, midnight, graveyard shift. But those were decorative terms now, like fireplace or stable. Nobody in the city did anything so inefficient as surrender eight hours to darkness.

I worked in adverse-effect oversight for Nexora Therapeutics, which meant I spent my life translating damage into acceptable vocabulary. Hallucination became sensory drift. Collapse became transient motor pause. Panic became adjustment distress. The system rewarded precision and punished drama, and I had gotten good enough at the job that I could calm myself with the shape of a report before I had read what it contained. The building itself helped. Soft glass. Responsive walls. Corridor lights that adjusted to your biometric calm score. Nexora liked to make even denial feel ergonomic.

That morning the queue held thirty-one flagged cases. Twenty-eight were the usual noise: users double-dosing to feel sharper, freelancers stacking unapproved stimulants on top of Vigil, one warehouse coordinator who had mistaken a migraine aura for a product event because the world no longer left room for ordinary suffering. The other three had been tagged by the pattern monitor under a new severity flag: intrusion-compatible phenomenology.

I hated the phrase on sight.

I opened the first file. Female, forty-two, municipal freight route supervisor, no prior psychiatric events, excellent adherence record. Subject reported "loss of roadway continuity" lasting forty-nine seconds, followed by inappropriate emotional response and recovered orientation. The transcript attached below had been redacted once already, which meant someone upstream had found it inconvenient.

I requested the full recording and took the descent elevator through three security skins to interview suite C.

Dalia Ventosa was waiting with both hands around a paper cup she was not drinking. She wore the orange reflective jacket of overnight freight, though overnight did not mean anything anymore except traffic density. Her eyes were bloodshot in the old way, the way people used to look after too little sleep. I noticed the detail and disliked myself for noticing it as evidence.

"Mr. Arce?" she said.

"Martin is fine."

"I already told the other one."

"Then tell me again."

That was not empathy. Repetition changed testimony. It showed you where memory hardened and where it leaked.

She let out one breath through her nose. "I was on the M-30 feeder with a clean load and full visibility. Then the road was gone."

"Gone how?"

"Not dark. Not blank. Gone." She watched my face to see whether I was going to file her under unstable. "I was in a corridor. Red carpet, white doors. Seven of them, maybe eight. There was music behind one door. Somebody was frying garlic. I knew I was late for something, only not for the route. For something older."

I kept my hands still on the table.

"How long did that last?"

"I don't know in there. Outside, they said forty-nine seconds." She swallowed. "When I came back I was three lanes over and halfway onto the emergency shoulder. The truck corrected because the guidance system caught it. If the system had been offline, I would have killed someone."

"Had you taken your scheduled dose?"

She laughed once, without humor. "You think I forgot the miracle drug that pays my mortgage?"

I let that pass. "What happened after orientation recovered?"

"I cried." She seemed ashamed of that more than of anything else. "Not because I was scared. Because I could still smell the garlic. Because for a second I knew that corridor better than the road I've driven every week for three years."

The recording had summarized this as inappropriate emotional response.

"Did the corridor feel familiar?" I asked.

"No. That's the worst part. It felt mine."

Something tightened under my ribs. I had read stranger statements and signed off on them with less thought than it took to drink a coffee. But Dalia spoke with the flat accuracy of people who had not decided whether they were allowed to be frightened yet.

"Any childhood sleep disorder?" I asked, because procedure demanded I ask.

"We don't do childhood sleep anymore," she said. "My son asked me last year what a bed was for before storage."

I almost smiled, but she was not joking.

When the interview ended, I stood in the observation corridor with the transcript open in my hand. Behind the one-way glass Dalia remained seated at the table, cup untouched, staring at the seam in the wall as if she expected it to open into another life.

My terminal vibrated against the smartglass rail. Vera Cid wanted the case disposition in under ten minutes.

I should have marked it moderate drift, environmental stress amplification, follow-up in thirty days. That was what the queue wanted from me. That was what the city wanted from all of us who worked for Nexora: not truth exactly, but continuity.

Instead I reopened the cluster view.

The other two cases had happened within six hours of Dalia's. A pediatric logistics scheduler in Seville who lost a minute in an elevator and reported hearing ocean surf inside the walls. A magistrate in Lyon who forgot the names of her children and then recalled a blue horse standing in her kitchen. All long-term users. All compliant. All recently pushed to the latest optimization band.

I requested archived comparators, expecting nothing, and got a permissions warning I had never seen before:

Legacy trial material contains unstable narrative events. Escalate only if operationally necessary.

Operationally necessary. Not medically. Not ethically. Operationally.

I sent Vera a holding note that bought me twenty minutes and left the building through the staff concourse. The concourse fed into the public metro under a banner the size of a chapel wall: VIGIL GAVE US THE HOURS WE DESERVED. The ad showed a woman barefoot in a sunlit kitchen at 02:00, smiling over a bowl of fruit as if she had personally defeated biology. Beneath it, a row of civic update kiosks pulsed green for users whose subscriptions were current.

The platform smelled of ozone and bakery fat. Trains arrived every ninety seconds because nothing in the city had to rest between cycles anymore. Above the tracks, retinal-safe guidance arrows crawled across a polymer ribbon, steering commuters by line color and productivity district. People stood with the clean alertness that had become more normal than drowsiness had ever been. Their faces were composed, productive, politely absent. A teenager in courier chrome blinked through a private overlay only he could see.

I boarded, found a place by the door, and opened Dalia's file again. I was reading the line about the corridor when the carriage lights fluttered.

It was a tiny thing. A half-second dip. Enough for any old grid. Enough for nobody else to care.

Then the handrail under my palm turned warm, almost fleshy, and I knew with total certainty that I was standing in the hall outside my mother's apartment.

The certainty was complete and insane. I smelled starch and the cheap jasmine soap she had used when I was a boy. I saw the brass number on the door, a dent in the lower panel where I had kicked a football into it at eleven, the thin line of yellow light underneath. Someone was sleeping inside. That fact came with the force of grief. Sleeping. Not absent, not dead, not optimized out of the species. Asleep.

When the train doors chimed, I was no longer on the carriage.

I was standing on the platform at Tribunal in front of apartment 4B, though there were no apartments there, only maintenance doors and a vending wall. My hand was raised as if I had been about to knock. Commuters went around me with clipped annoyance. A child in a school badge looked up at my face and pulled closer to his father. His lenses flashed as his guardian app tagged me as a possible disturbance.

My watch said I had lost fifty-seven seconds.

I lowered my hand slowly. On the dark glass of the vending wall my reflection looked ordinary, but there was sweat on my neck and an ache behind my eyes that felt older than the morning.

My work tablet had slipped half out of my bag. The archive request screen was still open, though I had no memory of touching it. One line sat expanded under the permissions warning, exposed as if I had tapped the wrong place while absent.

Phase III note, suppressed before rollout: Vigil maintained wake compliance but did not resolve sleep pressure. Dream-state processing persisted under constraint.

Below that, in a clipped hand I recognized from old internal training packets, someone had added a second line.

Intrusions were not exceptions. They were remainder.

I looked past my reflection and into the glass as if the platform itself might answer back. Behind me the city moved with its usual tireless speed. Somewhere above ground offices brightened toward a morning nobody needed. I had spent years helping to preserve that brightness. For the first time since I joined Nexora, it occurred to me that the hours we had been given were not free hours at all.

They were hours left over from something unpaid.

Chapter 2

I did not file Dalia before the deadline. Vera sent two messages, then one marked urgent, then came down to my station herself.

She had the kind of still face that made everyone around her perform order on instinct. Nothing in her expression suggested fatigue because nobody in our world was allowed to look as if they had been worn down by time.

"If this is caution," she said, "I admire it. If this is romanticism, I don't."

"The cluster isn't clean."

"No cluster is clean. That's why we have jobs."

I turned my monitor toward her. Dalia's transcript. The Lyon magistrate. The Seville scheduler. My unauthorized archive note, minimized but not gone.

Vera read quickly, one hand resting on the back of my chair. "These are still drift events."

"One of them nearly drove a freight carrier into a retaining wall."

"And did not. Because the system worked."

I wanted to tell her about the metro, about my mother's impossible apartment door, about the word asleep striking me like a physical blow. I said none of it. I had not yet decided whether silence was caution or cowardice.

"I want full archive access," I said.

Vera straightened. "Denied."

"On what basis?"

"On the basis that archived noise invites pattern delusion in analysts who have not reset recently."

Reset. Another polite word. She tapped the edge of my terminal. "Disposition the case as moderate drift. Recommend dosage review and hydration. Then go home for two hours."

"Nobody goes home for two hours."

"Then go somewhere with less glass," she said, and walked away.

I sent Ines Baeza a one-line message through an internal channel nobody monitored carefully because it had been built for dashboard maintenance:

Need historical intrusion comparators. Coffee?

She answered three minutes later.

Only if by coffee you mean treason.

We met at a public cafeteria under Plaza de Espana, one of the enormous sleepless halls where breakfast food and surgical scrubs and legal consultations were available at every hour. Clinics rented booths along the far wall. A pawn window glowed under a ramen sign. Half the tables had charging docks embedded in them for cuffs, tablets, and licensed neural accessories. The city had once used cafes to interrupt the day. Now they existed to prevent interruption.

Ines arrived carrying two paper cups and the expression of someone who had already decided the news was bad and was annoyed to have been right.

"You look awful," she said.

"Thank you."

"I mean clinically interesting."

I told her about Dalia. Not about my own intrusion. Then I showed her the archive note.

Ines read it without blinking. "You know they scrubbed most of Phase III from the live training repository."

"I know."

"You know that means somebody above Vera."

"Also yes."

She slid her cup toward me. "Good. Then I don't have to waste time warning you this is not a rogue manager softening a bad week. This is architecture."

Ines worked signal integrity, which meant she spent her days proving whether a pattern was real enough to deserve executive attention. She had an almost religious contempt for bad statistics and a practical loyalty to no one. There was an old cracked implant port behind her left ear that she never covered with makeup. If she was willing to say architecture, it meant she had already seen the shape of the lie.

"Can you get me the trial set?" I asked.

"Can? Yes. Should? No." She glanced up as servers moved behind the counter with the frictionless speed common to people who had not slept since adolescence. "There are ninety-one intrusion-compatible reports in the last twelve days. Public figure users are overrepresented. High cumulative exposure. Latest band update in eighty-six cases."

My mouth went dry. "Ninety-one?"

"That's just what survives the language filters." She lowered her voice. "There are more under transport error, emotional derealization, and workplace disorientation. Nobody wants the model to see a category if the category has legal consequences."

The lights above the pastry case blurred.

I looked down, expecting dizziness, and saw instead a white tablecloth under my hands. Porcelain. A bowl of green plums. Sun on a kitchen tile floor.

My mother sat across from me with her cheek resting in her palm. She was not dead in the vision because she had not yet died in that kitchen. She was only tired, the old human kind of tired that had once carried tenderness inside it. Her eyes were closed. Her breathing lifted one shoulder and let it fall.

"Martin."

Ines's voice came from far away. I tried to answer and heard a spoon ring against porcelain.

"Martin."

The tablecloth vanished. The cafeteria came back in a hard white snap. My cup had tipped over. Coffee spread across the table and onto my wrist. Ines had one hand around my forearm so tightly it hurt.

"How long?" I asked.

"Nine seconds." She studied me. "Do not lie to me now."

I wiped coffee from my cuff with the useless precision of panic. "The first one was fifty-seven."

Ines sat back. "And there it is."

For a moment neither of us spoke. Around us the cafeteria continued its smooth public hum. Trays slid. Screens updated. Cutlery touched ceramic. A sleepless civilization carried on with the confidence of something that did not know its own center was failing.

Ines opened her tablet and rotated it toward me.

"I pulled what I could before permissions narrowed," she said. "Animal trials first. Sleep architecture markers suppressed behaviorally, not neurologically. The mice kept moving while sections of their brains entered REM-pattern bursts. Then the human addenda. They called it segmented dream discharge."

Charts scrolled past: cortical activity spikes, emotional regulation metrics, memory fragmentation indices. Then a summary memo signed eighteen months before launch.

Long-term cumulative exposure likely to produce mixed-state cognition. Subject may remain motor-active while dream-state imagery and associative logic enter waking sensorium.

Below that, in a later hand:

Commercial risk of disclosure exceeds current harm profile. Continue monitoring.

I heard myself laugh, once, without amusement. "Current harm profile."

"Wait." Ines tapped again.

The next file was worse because it had numbers. Population adoption curves, exposure bands, convergence dates. A red projection window opened at the top of the graph.

At present expansion rate, reality-dream convergence event becomes probable in metropolitan high-density zones within 18-24 months.

"They're still pushing the booster next week," Ines said.

"What booster?"

"Adaptive update. New binding stabilizer. Public line is improved emotional smoothness and focus retention." Her mouth tightened. "Private line is market confidence."

Vera called while I was still reading. I almost let it ring out, then answered because defiance is cleaner after you know your ground.

"Where are you?" she asked.

"Off campus."

"Good. Stay there until you decide whether you're still employable."

"You knew."

There was a pause so small most people would not have heard it.

"I knew the same thing every adult in this industry knows," Vera said. "There is no intervention at scale without residue. Vigil gave the species usable time. We do not destabilize civilization because the body misses an obsolete rhythm."

"It isn't missing it," I said. "It's forcing it back in."

"In manageable fragments."

"You modeled convergence."

"We modeled scenarios. Martin, listen to me carefully. If confidence breaks, transport fails, hospitals fail, supply chains fail, half the labor law of Europe collapses in forty-eight hours. You are treating this as a moral puzzle because your sample size is human. Mine is social."

I looked at the graphs under my hand, at the red band crossing the city population curve like a wound.

"Then your sample size is wrong," I said, and ended the call.

Ines watched me in silence. After a moment she said, "If you leak this raw, they'll call it contaminated analysis from an unstable employee."

"They're not wrong about the unstable part."

"No," she said. "But they are wrong about the analysis."

She pushed another file across. This one was operational, not scientific. Distribution hub architecture. Certified update pathways. Municipal synchronization windows. I understood what she was showing me before she said it.

"The same system that pushes dose updates could push a reversal," I said.

"Not a cure. A restoration protocol. It would force people into actual sleep if enough receptors accepted it."

"At population scale?"

"Chaotically." She did not soften the word. "Ambulance demand would spike. Trains would halt. Offices would drop where they stood. Some people would resist the onset and injure themselves trying to stay vertical."

"And if nobody does it?"

Ines looked around the cafeteria, at the polished tile, the bright menu boards, the thousands of functioning strangers. "Then we wait until people start dreaming with both eyes open in operating theaters and control rooms."

The emergency feed on the wall changed. A transit advisory slid across the lower third in clean blue text: temporary service pause due to clustered orientation incidents on Lines 2 and 6. At the same time, half the room received the message through private overlays; I could tell by the synchronized refocusing of their eyes.

Clustered orientation incidents.

Somewhere in the city a train had filled with people who no longer fully agreed on where they were.

I closed the file and felt something inside me settle into place with the cold finality of a lock turning.

"Get me the update keys," I said.

Chapter 3

By midnight the city was still running, but it had begun to show seams.

Public screens carried soft advisories about transient orientation delays. Delivery routes rerouted around intersections where drivers had frozen at green lights with tears on their faces. A surgeon in Lavapies finished a procedure while describing snow that was not there. Two police officers walked into the lobby of a district court and failed to recognize the building they worked in. Above it all, the ad mesh kept trying to sell calm with discount hydration plans and upgrade financing. Nexora's official account posted reassurance every thirty minutes in the polished grammar of expensive certainty.

Vigil remains safe. Temporary drift events are rare. A precision update will improve user comfort.

Comfort.

I sat with Ines in an auxiliary maintenance room beneath Nexora's distribution hub, where the air smelled of coolant and dust sealed for too many years behind clean white walls. Fiber trunks ran overhead like exposed roots under frosted shielding. She had ghosted us through three permissions layers using credentials that would burn the instant the central system noticed where we were. On my tablet the restoration package waited in a locked queue beside the internal studies, the convergence projections, and the memos that proved executive knowledge.

"Once this goes," she said, "you don't get to call it a warning shot."

"I know."

"People are going to say you caused the collapse."

"Maybe I did."

Ines nodded as if that was the answer she trusted most. "Good. Then you understand the shape of it."

She had already done more than I had expected. She had pulled the key path, mapped the municipal sync window, and written the release note that would accompany the leak in language plain enough that panic might at least have a chance of becoming instruction.

If you are experiencing sensory overlap, confusion, memory discontinuity, or involuntary dream imagery, do not remain standing or operate machinery. The attached update suspends Vigil receptor maintenance and initiates sleep restoration. Seek a safe enclosed place.

It was the closest thing our civilization had to an evacuation order for reality.

The access door opened behind us.

Neither of us moved. There are moments when fear becomes so exact it behaves like concentration.

Vera stepped into the room with no security detail, no visible alarm, just a slate-gray coat over her work clothes and the expression she wore when a discussion had become tedious.

"Ines," she said. "Leave."

"No," Ines said.

Vera looked at me instead. "I am trying to prevent you from turning a contained medical problem into a civilizational event."

"It's not contained."

"It was containable."

She shut the door behind her. Somewhere above us pumps moved distribution stock through the building with a low arterial hum. It sounded obscenely alive.

"Do you know what happened when Vigil launched?" Vera asked. "Domestic accident rates fell. Long-haul fatalities fell. Emergency waiting lists halved. Parents got back a third of their working life. Entire regions came out of economic stagnation because time itself stopped being scarce in the old way. You think history will remember a few thousand drift events against that?"

"It won't stop at a few thousand."

"Because people like you escalate signal into catastrophe." For the first time her voice sharpened. "Bodies are conservative. Society cannot be."

I thought of Dalia gripping her untouched cup. The magistrate in Lyon forgetting her children. My own hand raised to knock on a door that had not existed for twenty years because some buried part of my mind had smelled jasmine and found a sleeping person inside the impossible.

"You call it residue because that's easier than calling it debt," I said. "We did not remove sleep. We repossessed it and left the brain to collect in fragments."

Vera's gaze moved to the locked queue on my tablet. "And your answer is to drop millions of people where they stand?"

"My answer is to stop pretending wakefulness is real just because it's profitable."

She held my eyes for a long moment. When she spoke again, the anger was gone, which made her more dangerous.

"Martin, if you release that protocol tonight, planes divert, trains halt, surgeries stall, security systems fail, markets suspend, and children watch adults fall unconscious in supermarkets and on stairwells and behind the wheel. There will be injuries. There may be deaths. If you wait, we can stage a managed transition."

"You had eighteen months."

That landed. Not dramatically. Just enough.

Ines had edged one hand toward the console without drawing Vera's attention. The sync countdown ticked in the corner of my screen: 00:01:12.

Vera saw it then and moved fast. Faster than I would have thought. She crossed the room and grabbed the tablet from my hand.

Ines hit the console.

For one terrible second nothing happened. Then the maintenance lights went out, the emergency strip at floor level came on red, and every display in the room flashed into manual recovery mode. Vera cursed under her breath. I had never heard her do that before. She was still holding the tablet, but the locked queue had already detached from local control and jumped to the sync buffer.

"What did you do?" she snapped.

"Bought us fourteen seconds," Ines said.

Vera lunged for the emergency kill panel.

I caught her wrist. She was stronger than I expected, all tendon and command. We hit the wall hard enough to jar my teeth. The tablet slid across the floor, screen bright in the red light. She drove an elbow into my chest. I lost air, kept hold, and felt the absurd intimacy of struggling with the woman who had taught me how to write risk summaries without legal exposure.

Above us a chime sounded through the building.

Municipal synchronization window open.

Vera froze. Not because she was afraid. Because she understood systems. She knew the sound meant the update had already gone wider than the room.

The emergency screens came alive one by one, not with Nexora branding but with the plain black-and-white release packet Ines had prepared. For a heartbeat the text stood there in silence. Then every connected device in the room, and likely in half the city, emitted the same soft confirmation tone.

Update received.

Vera closed her eyes.

It was the first time in all the years I had known her that she looked her age.

None of us spoke. There was nothing useful left to argue.

The first visible effect came seven minutes later.

We climbed to street level because staying underground felt like cowardice. Gran Via was still lit, but no longer with its old confidence. People had stopped moving at one shared velocity. Some sat down abruptly against shopfronts or on the curb, blinking as if light itself had become heavy. A man in a courier vest lay on his side beneath a pharmacy screen and slept with his mouth open while packages remained strapped to his back. A woman leaned against a bus shelter, smiled at no one, and slid carefully to the pavement

as though obeying a forgotten instruction. Above them, luxury towers kept projecting silent adverts into mist, but the images were already tearing where the building systems failed to refresh them.

Cars did not crash in the cinematic way I had feared. Most of them simply stopped. Smart traffic took over where it could. Elsewhere, engines idled while drivers bowed their heads onto their own arms. On balconies, in offices, across the glass faces of towers, lights began to go out in irregular handfuls. Not a blackout. A surrender.

Emergency sirens multiplied, then thinned as the responders themselves succumbed in waves and backup protocols took over. Somewhere distant I heard laughter, hysterical and relieved. Somewhere else I heard sobbing. The city had no shared script for what was happening. It only had bodies, and the bodies had remembered before the law did.

My own limbs had started to ache with a depth I had never known. Not pain exactly. Weight. As if years had rushed back into muscle and bone all at once, billing me for every borrowed hour.

Ines touched my sleeve. "You need to get inside before it hits fully."

"What about you?"

"I have three blocks." She gave me a look almost affectionate in its impatience. "Go home, Martin. Try not to be morally symbolic on the pavement."

Vera had remained a few steps away, watching the avenue change species around her. She did not look at me when she spoke.

"If this works," she said, "they'll call you a terrorist for a year and a savior after that. Or the reverse."

"If it works," I said, "they'll have to sleep first."

I left them there and walked east through a city that was becoming strange by becoming human again. Doorways were full of people lying under coats improvised into blankets. Offices had gone dim floor by floor. Branded wayfinding ribbons flickered and died across storefront glass. A bakery that had never closed in four years stood dark except for one back lamp burning over trays of cooling bread nobody would sell until morning.

At my building I climbed six flights because the lift had stalled between levels. My apartment had always felt temporary, designed for a life that only paused to shower and change clothes. I stood in the middle of it and saw, for the first time, how little room I had left for stillness.

Outside, the usual urban hum was collapsing into pockets. A siren. A far-off shout. Then less, and less.

I set my tablet on the counter and watched new alerts flood in: unauthorized biomedical release, municipal safety guidance, market suspension notices, legal injunctions already overtaken by biology. Under them all ran the same incoming feed from ordinary users:

I can smell my grandmother's house.

My son is asleep on the sofa. Is that normal.

I dreamed before I even reached the bed.

What do I do with eight dark hours.

I found an old blanket in storage and do not know why I am crying.

I went to the cupboard where I kept cleaning supplies and took out the folded spare duvet I had not used since launch. It smelled faintly of cardboard and lavender detergent. When I spread it over the bed, the gesture felt ceremonial and embarrassingly intimate, as if I were preparing a body. Maybe I was. The body that had waited underneath the schedules and dosage reminders and confidence metrics. The body that had not stopped asking for night just because we had made night unfashionable.

I lay down fully dressed. Through the window I could see only three towers still lit in any serious way. The rest of the city had gone soft. Not dead. Not defeated. Suspended in the oldest rhythm we had ever had.

For years we had called sleep a defect, a waste, a private failure of endurance. We had built an economy on the insult. Now the insult was over. The bill had arrived.

My eyes closed before I meant them to.

In the last second before I crossed over, I felt no corridor, no false kitchen, no dream intruding where it did not belong. Only the immense, almost unbearable relief of something finally happening in its proper place.